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## **Understanding the Impacts of past U.S. Intervention on Modern Immigration from Latin America**

The influx in Latin and South American immigration to the United States in the 21st century is directly tied to U.S. domination, interference, and occupation in those countries throughout the 20th century. The history of this involvement is depicted in the documentary *Harvest of Empire*, which was directed by Peter Getzels and Eduardo López, based on the book *Harvest of Empire: A History of Latinos in America*, written by Juan González. The documentary discusses the role of U.S. military and economic interests in Latin American countries, following the interrelated histories of the U.S. and Puerto Rico, Guatemala, Mexico, Cuba, the Dominican Republic, Nicaragua, and El Salvador. This film functions as education on U.S. involvement in Latin America, with the hope of shaping public understanding of immigration to the U.S. from these countries by explaining what has caused so many to seek asylum in the United States. *Harvest of Empire* demonstrates that those from Latin America that have immigrated to the United States have done so because U.S. intervention in their home countries have rendered them unlivable, forcing them to seek opportunity elsewhere.

The film begins with the history of Puerto Rico, the United States's oldest colony. Puerto Rico, like Cuba and the Philippines, were both gained by the United States in 1898 following the Spanish-American War. Unlike Cuba and the Philippines, however, Puerto Rico was never released as a U.S. colony, as American sugar companies held massive economic investment on the island and utilized Puerto Ricans as farm labor for sugarcane. In 1917, Puerto Ricans became U.S. citizens via the Jones-Shafroth Act and

20,000 were subsequently drafted by the U.S. to fight in World War II (Getzels & López, 2012). At that time, Puerto Ricans could not vote for their own governor, and both schools and the courts were solely conducted in English, rather than the native Spanish (Garcia & Sanchez, 2021, 69). Following the war, sweatshops in the industrial Northeast recruited Puerto Ricans to work in their factories, leading to over 1 million Puerto Ricans living on the mainland by 1960, outnumbering those on the island by 2003 (Getzels & López, 2012).

Following Puerto Rico, the intervention of the United States in Guatemala is discussed. In 1951, Guatemala elected its first democratic president, Jacobo Árbenz. At the time, two percent of landowners in Guatemala controlled seventy percent of arable land, creating widespread poverty (Getzels & López, 2012). Árbenz sought to reduce poverty by introducing land reform. This however, caught the attention of the United States, as the United Fruit Company was the largest landowner in Guatemala at the time. Due to this and other American interests in the country, the United States sought to overthrow the government to ensure better conditions for American businesses. Despite Árbenz being a democratically elected leader, U.S. propaganda presented him as a communist backed by the Kremlin, and promoted that he was overthrown to support democracy, as shown in the documentary via a news recording (Getzels & López, 2012, 0:15:42). Following Árbenz's deposition, Guatemala devolved into a civil war, lasting until the 1980s. The American installed government responded to rebels with a genocidal campaign. Decades later, declassified documents revealed the CIA had trained Guatemalan death squads. Allen Dulles, the head of the CIA during Árbenz's tenure as president, was one of the law partners representing the United Fruit Company (Getzels

& López, 2012). In the 1980s, less than two percent of Guatemalan applicants received asylum.

Mexico is a unique instance of U.S. involvement in Latin America. Prior to the Mexican-American War and the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo, the northern territory of Mexico was sparsely populated. Mexico understood that without higher population numbers, their land would be easily taken by the United States as they expanded West (Getzels & López, 2012). As a result, Mexico welcomed presumably Irish Catholic immigrants to help boost population numbers. The defining characteristic of these immigrants, however, was their slave ownership, as they saw Texas and other Mexican territory as an opportunity to expand slavery in North America, despite the Mexican government abolishing slavery in 1829 via the Guerrero Decree, leading to the Mexican-American War and the annexation of Texas. As discussed by Lorenzo Meyer, a historian and political analyst, the United States sought to take as much Mexican land as possible while annexing as few Mexican people to prevent the cultural contamination they feared would ensue by introducing large numbers of Mexicans as U.S. citizens (Getzels & López, 2012, 0:29:28). This strategy shaped the land borders in the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo (1848) and resulted in few people being there to mine resources. Post-annexation, the western United States relied greatly on Mexicans to supply labor until the Great Depression, where fear over competition with Mexicans for jobs led the Hoover administration to begin a massive deportation campaign, where up to 60% may have been U.S. citizens (Getzels & López, 2012). This begins a cycle for the United States, where Mexicans are recruited for labor during times of economic growth and removed when the economy is troubled. Another push for Mexican labor came following

Pearl Harbor, where a decline in European immigrants and Americans fighting overseas resulted in the *Braceros* program, which imported Mexicans to guarantee a steady flow of labor (Getzels & López, 2012). This fear over Mexicans and other Latinos influencing political decisions taking economic opportunities away from those already in the U.S. has continued to this day (McClain & Johnson Carew, 2017, 264-265).

Cuban immigrants to the United States primarily come as political refugees as a direct result of U.S. actions in Cuban affairs. Following the Spanish-American War, the 1903 Platt Amendment gave the United States the right to intervene in Cuban affairs to protect American interests on the island. As was the case throughout Latin America, the United States occupied Cuba, rewrote its laws to favor American interests, then installed a dictator to continue those goals (Getzels & López, 2012). Fulgencio Batista was installed by the United States and was overthrown by the Cuban people due to their dissatisfaction with American policies within Cuba and the subjugation of the Cuban people. This led to the rise of Fidel Castro, who in 1961 led his army to defeat CIA-trained exiles in the Bay of Pigs invasion to take over the island. Castro implemented health and education programs for lower-class Cubans, pushing out the middle- and upper-class opposition, who began entering the United States in 1962. In the 1980s, 125,000 Cubans entered Miami via flotillas, resulting in anger towards bilingualism and Miami-Dade County's "English only" ordinance, which prohibited the use of Spanish in government agencies (Getzels & López, 2012). This surge of Cuban immigration turned Miami into a hub of Latin influence in America, electing their first Cuban mayor in 1985.

The Dominican Republic saw one of the earliest examples of American intervention in Latin America. In 1916, the U.S. Army trained a new Dominican national guard, handpicking Rafael Trujillo as the leader who used the military to seize control of the Dominican government (Getzels & López, 2012). Trujillo was an extremely violent dictator, ruling the Dominican Republic with total control for 30 years. While he made it extremely easy for U.S. companies to conduct business in the Dominican Republic, he would also disappear and kill Dominicans and American citizens with impunity, leading the CIA to join with disgruntled Dominican military officers to back his assassination. A few decades later, Juan Bosch was elected president in 1963. A liberal social democrat, Bosch aimed to implement social reforms in the Republic until a military coup spurred a popular insurrection a few months into his tenure. This resulted in the United States invasion of the Dominican Republic in 1965. After the rebels surrendered, the U.S. government scheduled new elections, allowing Trujillo's right-hand man, Joaquín Balaguer, to run and eventually win the election. During his tenure, killings of Bosch forces ensued on almost a daily basis, leading the United States to allow rebels to enter as refugees, with thousands entering New York City.

In Nicaragua, the Somoza family, installed by the United States, controlled the country from 1936-1979. Anastasio Somoza and his sons, Luis and Anastasio, came from poverty and sought to enrich themselves and their inner circle while being as brutal as Trujillo was in the Dominican Republic (Getzels & López, 2012). The assassination of journalist Pedro Joaquín Chamorro Cardenal in 1978 caused banks and businesses in Nicaragua to go on strike, halting the economy. The Church, students, farmers, and urban dwellers joined with the banks and businesses, toppling the Somoza regime in

July 1979. Following the revolution, President Carter recognized the Sandinista National Liberation Front (Sandista's) as the legitimate government of Nicaragua. Some of those who fought alongside the Sandista's were denied influence in the new government, eventually forming an opposition group known as the *Contras* who would arrest and torture young Nicaraguans. The United States was caught secretly funding the Contras by the Iran-Contras affair, where the United States sold surface-to-air missiles to Iran, placed those profits into a Swiss bank, then passed them to the Contra's to support them against the Sandinista's in circumvention of American law. The International Court of Justice found this to be in violation of international law in the case *Nicaragua v. United States* (1986). In 1997, the U.S. Congress extended legal residency to thousands of Nicaraguan refugees, who fled to the United States to escape the turmoil funded by the U.S.

Finally, El Salvador is one of the most recent examples of U.S. intervention in Latin America. Salvadoran death squads sought out anyone who spoke out against American policies, including Archbishop Romero, who was assassinated on March 30, 1980 (Getzels & López, 2012). At his funeral, there was a bombing followed by open fire on attendees, killing Salvadoran and American citizens who spoke out against the regime. It was later discovered that the Salvadoran military members who tortured, raped, and killed civilians were trained at the School of the Americas, a U.S. Army training facility that produced some of the worst tyrants in South American history. In 1986, President Regan signed the Immigration Reform and Control Act, which produced the largest legalization of undocumented immigrants in U.S. history, with approximately 3 million becoming legal immigrants. Of the \$4 billion in U.S. aid throughout the 1980s

to El Salvador, 70% was spent on weapons (Getzels & López, 2012). Less than three percent of applicants were granted political asylum during the civil war.

In conclusion, Getzels and López demonstrate that the current influx of immigrants from Latin and South America into the United States is directly tied to past U.S. interventionist policies in those regions. By educating viewers on the past actions of the United States in those regions, Getzels and López seek to impart understanding of the circumstances that drive people to flee their home countries in the hope of a better life in the United States.

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